Lesson 31: Research Writing: A Model Essay and the Purpose of Research

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 4: Research and Evidence

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 3.1 Introduction; 3.2 Sample Student Research Essay: Faculty of Color; 3.3 Purpose of Research Writing.

In this lesson

You read a student research essay, "Where are the Professors Who Look Like Me?", think about why people do research, and compare how an academic paper and an online article show their sources. You also choose topics for your own small research project, which continues until Lesson 39. University courses, including psychology, expect you to find sources, judge them and use them to support your own ideas.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain why people do research and write research papers.
- Name the four steps that everyday research and academic research share.
- Find the thesis, the evidence and the writer's explanations in a model research essay.
- Compare how a research paper and an online article show where their information comes from.
- Choose possible topics for your own research project.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
research paper	an essay that uses information from sources to support the writer's own argument	Lily's essay on minority faculty
research question	the question that you try to answer through your research	Why is it important to have more minority faculty in colleges?
source	a book, article, website, video, etc. that gives information	an EdSource article
cite, citation	to show where you got information from; the reference that shows it	"... are people of color (Peele and Willis)."
in-text citation	the author's name (and page, if there is one) in the sentence that uses the source	(Stout et al)
Works Cited	the list of all sources at the end of a paper in MLA style	the last page of Lily's essay

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
credible, credibility	can be trusted; the quality of being trusted	Do the links give the writer more credibility?
faculty (of color)	the teachers of a college or university (who are not white)	Almost all of my professors have been white.
underrepresented	present in smaller numbers than in the population as a whole	Minority faculty members are underrepresented.
In other words, ...	introduces your own explanation of a source	In other words, minority faculty can inspire students.
We can infer that ...	introduces a conclusion that you draw from evidence	We can infer that Jesus and students like him would feel less "erased" ...
qtd. in	"quoted in": the words come from a person quoted in another writer's source	(qtd. in Peele and Willis)

Rules and explanations

Why we research

- You already do research, for example to find the cheapest laptop: you search online, compare results, decide how much you trust each one, make a decision and explain it to others. Academic research has the same four steps: **find** information, **analyze** it, **make a decision**, and **share** it.
- In a research paper, you use the facts and opinions you find to support **your own argument**. You find out what others know and believe about a topic and use it to guide your own thinking. This helps you clarify your ideas, think critically and share your own voice persuasively.

A model research essay: what to notice

Lily Liu De Li, an ESL student at Laney College in Oakland, California, wrote "Where are the Professors Who Look Like Me? Increasing Minority Faculty in Higher Education". The chapter follows her research journey.

Part	What Lily does
Introduction	her own experience, a statistic with a citation, then the thesis (last sentence)
Body paragraphs	a topic sentence (her claim), evidence from sources (statistics, quotations, paraphrases) with citations, then her own explanation
Conclusion	the problem and its main cause again, then her personal hope
Works Cited	the full details of her sources, in alphabetical order (two are missing: see Exercise 3, question 8)

The pattern of a research paragraph is **claim, cited evidence, explanation**. Claim: faculty of color "bring many benefits to their campuses". Evidence: "Students of color are more likely to graduate if

they have more minority faculty (Stout et al)." Explanation: "This is an enormous benefit and should cause colleges to rethink their policies."

How sources are shown

An academic paper uses **in-text citations** and a **Works Cited page**: "... only about 40 percent of the professors are people of color (Peele and Willis)." An online article uses **links**: in "About four in five public school teachers are white", the words "are white" link to official data. Both let readers check the information. Remember the rhetorical appeals (Lesson 13): **ethos** (the writer's credibility), **pathos** (emotion), **logos** (logic, facts, evidence).

Your research project (Lessons 31 to 39)

While you follow Lily, you do a small project in the same steps: topics (Lesson 31); a narrow topic and research question (32); keywords, free sources and evaluation (33); reading articles and an annotated bibliography (34); evidence and citations (35 to 39). Choose any topic you care about. One psychology option, used as the example in these guides: **sleep and memory in university students** (PSYC 110 discusses memory; the free OpenStax textbook *Psychology 2e* covers sleep in chapter 4 and memory in chapter 8).

> **Psychology note:** Lily uses MLA style (Modern Language Association), common in English classes. Psychology uses APA style (American Psychological Association): the in-text citation includes the year, for example (Davis & Fry, 2019), and the list at the end is called References.
>
> **Note for Arabic speakers** - The Arabic word for "research" has a plural, but English *research* is uncountable: "do research", "a research project", "a study, two studies". Do not write "a research" or "many researches".

Practice

Exercise 1. Before you read (3.1 and 3.3). Make notes, then discuss with your tutor.

1. In your education, were your teachers of the same race or background as you? How did that affect your learning?
2. When did you last research something to find an answer or to persuade someone? How did you choose where to look? Did you trust all the sources? What did you do with the information?

Exercise 2. Why we research. Read 3.1 and 3.3 in the lesson material. True or false?

1. Everyday research is only finding information.
2. When you search online, you compare the results and decide how much you trust each one.
3. In a research paper, you use facts and opinions from sources to support your own argument.
4. In a research paper, your own ideas do not matter; you only report what experts think.
5. Academic papers show sources with in-text citations and a Works Cited page; online articles show them with links.
6. Research can help you organize your own thoughts on a topic.

Exercise 3. The model essay. Read Lily's essay (3.2) in the lesson material.

1. Copy her thesis statement. Where is it?
2. Which personal experience and which statistic open the essay?
3. Name three benefits of faculty of color from the first body paragraph.
4. What extra responsibilities do faculty of color often take on, according to Cleveland et al.?
5. Why can this extra work harm their careers? (the paragraph that begins "However, the extra responsibilities")
6. What solution does Lily describe in the paragraph that begins "One promising way"?
7. Find four different phrases that introduce Lily's own explanations of her sources.
8. Compare her in-text citations with her Works Cited list. Which two sources are missing from the list? Which in-text citation uses a different name from the list?

Exercise 4. Notice this! An online research article (3.3). Read Lasana D. Kazembe's article in the lesson material, then skim the original online (see "Watch online"), which has links.

1. How do the links affect you as a reader? Did you click any? Do they give the writer more credibility? Do they provide ethos, pathos or logos?
2. The sentence "About four in five public school teachers are white, according to the latest official data" has a link. Where does it go? How would a research paper show this source?
3. Kazembe writes, "Research indicates that students of color benefit from being taught by people who look like them." Which sentence in Lily's first body paragraph makes a similar point, and how does she show her source?

Exercise 5. One student's research journey (end of 3.3). Lily noticed that few of her instructors were Asian American, Black, Latinx or Native American. How would you research this topic? Write three or four questions you would want to answer.

Exercise 6. Start your project. Write down three topics that you care about and would like to read about for several weeks. Include at least one psychology topic.

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me the questions in Exercise 1, with follow-up questions. Then correct my mistakes, especially with 'research'."
- "Quiz me on Lily's essay: five questions about her thesis, evidence and Works Cited list."
- "Here is my explanation of a quotation from Lily's essay: [paste]. Does it show how the evidence supports her thesis?"
- "Play an administrator who thinks faculty diversity is not important. I will argue using Lily's evidence. After five turns, tell me which of my points were strongest."
- "Here are three topics for my research project: [list]. Ask me questions to find out which one I care about most."

Read aloud

Sentences from Lily's essay. Pause briefly at each / and stress the words in bold.

1. While almost **75 percent** of California Community College students are people of color, / only about **40 percent** of the professors are people of color.
2. Students of color are **more likely** to graduate / if they have more minority faculty.
3. In other words, / minority faculty can **inspire** students / and show them a path forward.
4. As this quotation suggests, / individual people may **know** what needs to be done to make changes, / but they might not "reach out" and ask for changes / if they don't have **social support**.

Writing task

Write one paragraph of 200 to 250 words. Choose one topic:

1. In your education, were your teachers of the same background as you? How did that affect your learning? Use one piece of evidence from Lily's essay and say where it comes from ("In her research essay, Lily Liu De Li reports that ...").
2. Describe one piece of everyday research that you did. Then explain how it is similar to academic research, using the four steps: find, analyze, decide, share.

Include a clear claim, specific support, an explanation ("In other words, ...") and a concluding sentence.

Self-editing checklist:

- Does my topic sentence make one clear claim?
- Is my support specific, not only general statements?
- Did I explain how my support proves the claim?
- If I used information from Lily's essay, did I say where it comes from?
- Did I put exact words from a text in quotation marks?
- Did I use "research" as an uncountable noun?
- Are my sentences complete, without run-ons or comma splices?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- The original article by Lasana D. Kazembe, with its links (Exercise 4): https://theconversation.com/i-prepare-aspiring-teachers-to-educate-kids-of-color-heres-how-i-help-them-root-out-their-own-biases-141761

Answer key

Exercise 1 (example answers)

1. "At school, all my teachers shared my background, so I felt comfortable asking questions."
2. "I compared laptop prices on three websites, trusted detailed reviews more than short ones, chose a mid-price model and explained my choice to my brother."

Exercise 2

1. False: it is finding information, analyzing it, making a decision and sharing it.
2. True.
3. True.
4. False: you use what others know to guide your own thinking and share your own voice.
5. True.
6. True.

Exercise 3

1. "Although minority faculty members play an important role on campuses, their contributions are often not recognized and colleges should find more ways to support and retain them." It is the last sentence of the introduction.
2. In four years at Laney College, almost all her professors were white, although her city is very diverse. Almost 75 percent of California Community College students are people of color, but only about 40 percent of the professors are (Peele and Willis).
3. Any three: more students of color graduate (Stout et al); performance gaps can close by 20% to 50% (Davis and Fry); students see them as role models (Davis and Fry); all students meet diverse perspectives, which helps them work in a multicultural society (Paganelli and Cangemi).
4. Being expert advisors on diversity, serving on committees related to diversity, and translating for English learners.
5. The extra work is "ignored in the faculty reward system, especially the awarding of tenure" (Aguirre); tenure is a permanent position. Faculty are promoted for research and teaching, and the extra jobs take attention away from these, so their evaluations can suffer; some become overwhelmed and leave the field.
6. More support and community, for example the University of Minnesota's culturally responsive mentoring program (Han and Onchwari), which helped faculty of color feel more community and ask the administration for changes together.
7. "In other words, ..." (four times); "We can infer that ..."; "Basically, we can assume that ..."; "As this quotation suggests, ...". Also possible: "This is because ..." (her own reason, without a citation, in the paragraph on tenure).
8. Missing: Cleveland et al. and Johnson and Scafide (both are in her annotated bibliography, Lesson 34). Different name: "(Jones et al)" refers to Bryan McKinley Jones Brayboy, listed as "Brayboy", so it should be (Brayboy et al.).

Exercise 4

1. (example answer) "The links make me trust the writer more, because I can check his facts. They add ethos (he has done research) and logos (facts and statistics, such as the suspension rates of 13.5% and 3.5%)."
2. To the National Center for Education Statistics (nces.ed.gov), a US government website for education statistics. A research paper would add an in-text citation, for example (National Center for Education Statistics), and the full details in the Works Cited list.
3. "Students of color are more likely to graduate if they have more minority faculty (Stout et al)." (The Davis and Fry quotation about performance gaps is also correct.) She uses an in-text citation in parentheses and a full entry in her Works Cited list.

Exercise 5 (example answer) How many faculty of color are there compared with students of color? Why does it matter for students? What problems do faculty of color face? What can colleges do to hire and keep them? (Compare with Lily's questions in Lesson 32.)

Exercise 6 (example answer) sleep and memory in university students; stress and coping among international students; keeping a heritage language in a new country.

My notes